Lesson 17: Reading Profiles 1: An Employee, Reynolds, Student Spotlights

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): 1.1: Video: Amazon Employee Profile; 1.2: Reading: Profile Reynolds; 1.3: Reading: Student Spotlights.

In this lesson

You will study three kinds of profile: a company video about an employee, an article about the park ranger Leslie Reynolds, and two university "student spotlights". You will learn what a profile is, find facts and quotations, learn career and college words, and write the questions the writer asked in the interview.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Describe the main features of a profile.
- Name the genre, audience and purpose of a profile.
- Find facts and quotations in a profile.
- Use career words such as "recipient", "inspire", "mentor" and "rewarding".
- Write the open-ended questions an interviewer asked to write a profile.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
profile	a short text or video about one person	The article is a profile of a park ranger.
recipient (n)	a person or thing that receives something	the 2015 recipient of the Harry Yount National Park Ranger Award
inspire (v)	make someone feel that they want to do something and can do it	Reynolds continues to inspire the new generation of park rangers.
mentor (v)	advise or train someone younger or less experienced	She enjoys developing and mentoring others.
rewarding (adj)	giving satisfaction	a career that is rewarding
challenge (v)	give someone a task that needs great effort	a career that continues to challenge me every day
major (n)	the main subject you study at college	In her second year, Jennifer chose Civil Engineering.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
despite	even though; in spite of (before a noun phrase)	Despite my head cold, I went to work today.
open-ended question	begins with a wh- word and allows a long answer	Why did you decide to attend Stony Brook University?

Rules and explanations

What is a profile?

A profile is about **one person** (anyone, not only famous people). It is **short** and gives **a few facts** about the person's history. It focuses on **one part** of their life (work, school, a hobby or a special interest). It has a **positive tone**.

Genre, audience, purpose and quotations

- **Genre**: what kind of text it is and where you find it. **Audience**: who reads it. **Purpose**: why it was made (to inform, to convince...).
- Clues: the topic, the format, the register (formal or informal), the pictures and the vocabulary.
- A **quotation** is a person's exact words inside quotation marks: "word word word." Most profiles use quotations. Ask: who is speaking?

Profiles come from interviews

The writer first interviews the person. You can work backwards: read a paragraph and write the question the writer asked. Good interviewers ask **open-ended questions**: they begin with a wh-word and allow a long answer.

- Closed: Did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? (yes or no)
- Open-ended: Why did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? (long answer)

Collocations (words that often go together)

recipient of; award to; develop a program/business/system/method; inspire (someone) to do (something); rewarding job/career/work; challenge (someone) to do (something); mentor (someone); journey to/through/from

Despite

"Despite" means "even though" or "in spite of": the person was not stopped by something. Put a noun phrase after it: Despite the difficulty of the final exam, the students passed the class.

U.S. college words

freshman (1st year), sophomore (2nd), junior (3rd), senior (4th). Undergraduate students study for an associate's (2-year) or bachelor's (4-year) degree; graduate students study after the bachelor's (master's, doctorate). To declare a major = to officially choose your main subject.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic questions have no extra helping verb, but English past wh-questions need "did" before the subject: "Where did you go to high school?" (not "Where you went to high school?").

Practice

1. Video: an employee profile. Watch the Amazon employee profile (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IoyvKtwXqeA) and choose. a) Where would you expect to see this video? On Instagram / On a dating website / On a college website / On a company website b) Audience (all that apply): The company Amazon / The general public / John's friends and family / A company that needs employees c) Purpose (all that apply): To help John find a new job / To explain step by step how to get hired at Amazon / To show how happy an employee is working for Amazon / To make the company feel more personal by introducing some of its employees d) Which features of a profile (see "What is a profile?") can you see in this video?

2. Reynolds: comprehension. Read "Congratulations to the 2015 recipient of the Harry Yount National Park Ranger Award!" a) Who is the profile about, and what organization does she work for? b) Where does she work now, and what is her job title? c) Where did she work in the past, and what job titles did she have? d) What programs and teams did she start or serve? e) What is the name of the award, and what organization gave it to her? f) Who is speaking in the final paragraph (with quotation marks)? g) What are three of her professional accomplishments? h) What inspires her, in her own words? i) Purpose: To inform readers of the services at the park / To convince readers that Leslie Reynolds is an excellent employee / To persuade readers to visit a national park / To educate readers about the dangers at the park j) Why do organizations give awards? Choose all possible answers and add one: To motivate employees to do a good job / To inform employees and visitors of the expectations for a good employee / To convince customers/visitors that the organization has good employees / To make employees feel valuable k) The article is mostly about her _____ life. (professional / personal) l) She has worked for the National Park Service for _____ years.

3. Vocabulary: match. 1 recipient; 2 award; 3 develop; 4 inspire; 5 lead through example; 6 rewarding; 7 challenge; 8 mentor; 9 journey; 10 public service a) to create or produce especially by deliberate effort over time; b) something suggesting travel from one place to another; c) an activity or job paid for by the government and meant to help everyone; d) to advise or train someone younger or less experienced; e) to act in a way that shows others how to act; f) a person or thing that receives something; g) a prize in honor of an achievement; h) to present a task that requires great effort; i) providing satisfaction; j) to make someone feel that they want to do something and can do it

4. Vocabulary: fill in the blanks with words from exercise 3. Change the form if needed.

1. In the 1980's, my family took a long _____ by plane from the U.S. to Mauritius.
2. People who work with computers always _____ new programs to help their customers.
3. Learning a new language _____ us in ways we never imagined. It's hard!
4. Instead of a job at a big corporation, I decided to find a job with the government in _____.
5. A good role model like Martin Luther King, Jr. can _____ people to make changes in the world.

6. She enjoys her job because it's _____. Every day she goes home feeling satisfied.
7. The _____ of the Oscar often cry when they give their speeches.
8. The Oscar is the highest _____ for movies, and the Tony is the highest _____ for theater.
9. If you want your children to do the right thing, you must _____. You have to be a good role model.
10. His boss _____ him and helps him learn how to do his job well.

5. Student spotlights: comprehension. Read the profiles of Jennifer Moy and Shivani Mishra. a) Who is the author of both profiles? What are their titles and dates? b) What institution published them? How did you find the answer? c) Audience (all that apply): People who work at Stony Brook University / Students who attend it / People who want to attend it in the future / Students at other universities d) Make a chart for both students: where she grew up; high school; current major; future plans; where she works now.

6. The interviewer's questions. a) Read the first paragraph of both profiles. Example: "Where did you go to high school?" Write two more questions the writer asked. b) Spotlight #1, second paragraph. Which question did the interviewer ask Jennifer? Where did you decide to go to college? / Where is your new home? / Why did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? / Did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? c) Spotlight #2, second paragraph. Write an open-ended question the writer probably asked Shivani. d) Who said the quotation "I grew up in a city full of towers and skyscrapers..."?

Speak with your tutor

- "You are Leslie Reynolds, the park ranger. I am a journalist. I will interview you about your career with open-ended questions. Correct my questions if they are wrong."
- "You are Christopher Larson. Interview me for a 'Student Spotlight' about my studies or my job. Ask one open-ended question at a time."
- "Read me a sentence from one of the profiles. I will write the question the writer asked to get that information. Correct my question."
- "Give me 5 yes/no questions about the student spotlights. I will change each one into an open-ended question."

Read aloud

1. re·CIP·i·ent, a·WARD, de·VEL·op, in·SPIRE
2. MEN·tor, re·WARD·ing, JOUR·ney, PUB·lic SER·vice
3. de·SPITE, se·MES·ter, DOR·mi·to·ry, AR·chi·tec·ture
4. Why did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? (↘)
5. Did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? (↗)

Writing task

Write a short paragraph about a job or career that was, or will be, rewarding for you. Use at least five words from the word bank in exercise 3, with their collocations (for example "inspire someone to do something", "a rewarding career"). Then read it to your tutor and ask for corrections.

Watch online

- Amazon employee profile video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IoyvKtwXqeA

Answer key

1. (example answer; the book says answers may vary) a) On a company website. b) The general public. c) To show how happy an employee is working for Amazon; to make the company feel more personal by introducing some of its employees. d) It is about one person, it is short, it focuses on his work, and it has a positive tone.

2. a) Leslie Reynolds; the National Park Service. b) Cape Cod National Seashore, Massachusetts; chief ranger. c) Yosemite, Grand Canyon and Shenandoah National Parks; law enforcement ranger, officer, medic, instructor, investigator and counselor. d) She helped develop the Preventative Search & Rescue (PSAR) programs at Yosemite and Shenandoah; she served on the Critical Incident Stress Management Team. e) The Harry Yount National Park Ranger Award; the National Park Service (the article does not say this directly). f) Leslie Reynolds. g) Any three: she helped save hikers, injured climbers and accident victims; she helped develop the PSAR programs; she served on the stress management team; she became chief ranger. h) "My inspiration comes mostly from the rangers of the National Park Service." i) To convince readers that Leslie Reynolds is an excellent employee. j) All four are possible. (example answer) Another reason: to thank employees in public. k) professional. l) 21 (the article says "her 21-year career").

3. 1 f; 2 g; 3 a; 4 j; 5 e; 6 i; 7 h; 8 d; 9 b; 10 c.

4. 1 journey; 2 develop; 3 challenges; 4 public service; 5 inspire; 6 rewarding; 7 recipients; 8 award, award; 9 lead through example; 10 mentors.

5. a) Christopher Larson. "Student Spotlight--Meet Jennifer Moy", November 20, 2019; "Student Spotlight--Shivani Mishra", December 11, 2019. b) Stony Brook University (its library). Clues: both students work in Stony Brook libraries, and the web addresses begin "library.stonybrook.edu". c) (example answer) The first three. d)

	Jennifer Moy	**Shivani Mishra**
Grew up	the Bronx; moved to Brooklyn at 14	Long Island
High school	Frank McCourt High School	Half Hollow Hills High School
Major	Civil Engineering	Physics
Future plans	bachelor's degree by May 2021; specialize in structural engineering	combine medicine and physics in biomedical research
Works now	Health Sciences Library	a Stony Brook library, as a student library assistant

6. a) (example answer) Where did you grow up? When did your family move to Brooklyn? b) Why did you decide to attend Stony Brook University? c) (example answer) How did you choose your major? d) Jennifer Moy.

My notes